



Discovering life

Ever since people first began to observe the natural world around them, they have been making discoveries about life and living things.

Biology—the scientific study of life—emerged in the ancient world when philosophers studied the diversity of life’s creatures, and medical experts of the day dissected bodies to see how they worked. Hundreds of years later, the invention of the microscope opened up the world of cells and microbes, and allowed scientists to understand the workings of life at the most basic level. At the same time, new insights helped biologists answer some of the biggest questions of all: the cause of disease, and how life reproduces.

Timeline of discoveries

More than 2,000 years of study and experiment has brought biology into the modern age. While ancient thinkers began by observing the plants and animals around them, scientists today can alter the very structure of life itself.